



MAMATA BANERJEE GIVES FINAL TOUCHES TO THE RAILWAY BUDGET

Ticket to BENGAL

For Mamata Banerjee, Rail Bhavan is the track to the chief minister's chair in Kolkata's Writers' Building

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

From the day Mamata Banerjee took over as the railway minister from Kolkata, she has not even tried to make a pretence that her heart, mind and soul lie in the Writers' Building. Rail Bhavan is merely a stepping stone for her to achieve her ultimate ambition of occupying the chief minister's chair in West Bengal. Of her first 40 days in office, Banerjee has spent 25 in Kolkata, making Railway Board officials travel frequently from Delhi, carrying even routine files for her signature. The to-and-fro travel became more frequent in the run-up to the Railway Budget

on July 3. The final budget document only underlined the fact that from her oft-repeated alliterative phrase of "Maa, Maati and Maanush" (mother, motherland and man), it is motherland West Bengal that took precedence over everything else. From giving the state 21 new trains, promising it 109 model stations to establishing a coach factory at Kanchrapara and a 1,000-MW power plant at Adra in Purulia, Banerjee went the whole hog to please the disenchanted electorate. She also announced the extension of the Eastern section of the Dedicated Freight Corridor up to Dankuni and setting up of an Eastern Industrial Corridor.

According to the officials,

Banerjee will find it difficult to fulfill most of her promises as the Railways did not have resources to undertake so many new projects. "On one hand, she is announcing taking over ailing wagon units such as Braithwaite and Burn Standard, on the other she talks about setting up a new coach factory in her state. There is just no demand for a new coach factory," moaned a railway official. Of the 307 stations identified to be converted into model stations, more than half are in West Bengal, of which many hardly have any traffic.

Where Banerjee could not offer a new train or promise a new line, she promised surveys. This was done to accommodate Singur,